

Brazil votes as Lula and Flávio Bolsonaro lead the polls

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People in Brazil began voting on 4 October 2026. Twelve **candidates** want to be president. Current president Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva and Flávio Bolsonaro lead **opinion poll**surveys asking people whom they support.

Lula belongs to the left-wing Workers' Party. Flávio is a right-wing politician and former president Jair Bolsonaro's son. Left-wing and right-wing mean different ideas about running a country.

Four years ago, Lula beat Jair Bolsonaro by a small amount. Jair is not running now. He is under **house arrest** after being found guilty of planning to overturn the election result. He cannot post on social media or make public statements. The source says he supports his son's campaign.

Only Lula and Flávio have at least 10% support in polls. Surveys suggest a second vote, called a **run-off**, is very likely. But many voters had not decided shortly before election day. Someone could still win in the first round.

Almost 160 million Brazilians can vote. People can start voting at 16. Those aged 18 to 70 who can read and write must vote or face a fine. Polls usually ask only thousands of people, so results may be very different.

Lula is 80 and has been president three times. During his first two terms, from 2003 to 2010, many praised his Bolsa Família cash-support programme for helping millions leave **poverty**. His later convictions for corruption and money laundering were cancelled in 2021. He has always denied those crimes.

Some environmentalists have criticised recent actions. Lula says oil money can help pay for cleaner energy. He says he still plans to end fossil-fuel use eventually. His government points to satellite information suggesting Amazon forest loss in the first half of 2026 reached its lowest level in ten years.

Word Treasure

candidate -- Someone who wants to be chosen for a position, such as president.

opinion polls -- Surveys that ask people whom they support.

run-off -- A second round of voting.

house arrest -- Being required to stay at home by the authorities.

poverty -- Not having enough money for basic needs.

Break it down

The opening gives the voting date and names the two poll leaders.

The next paragraphs explain the candidates' political groups and Jair Bolsonaro's situation.

The middle explains the possible second vote, voting rules and limits of polls.

The ending describes Lula's record on poverty, court convictions and the environment.

Why it matters

Almost 160 million Brazilians can vote in an election to choose their president. Polls give clues about support, but the result is still uncertain.

Test what you remember

1. When did people in Brazil begin voting?
 - (A) In the first half of 2010
 - (B) 4 October 2026
 - (C) During 2003
 - (D) 4 October 2021
2. How is Flávio Bolsonaro related to Jair Bolsonaro?
 - (A) He is Jair's father.
 - (B) They are cousins.
 - (C) He is Jair's brother.
 - (D) He is Jair's son.
3. What do surveys suggest is very likely?
 - (A) Jair Bolsonaro becoming a candidate
 - (B) All twelve candidates winning
 - (C) A second vote, called a run-off
 - (D) An election with no voters
4. Which people must vote or face a fine?
 - (A) People aged 18 to 70 who can read and write
 - (B) Only people who are 16
 - (C) Everyone over 70
 - (D) Only the twelve candidates
5. Why might the election results be very different from the polls?
 - (A) Polls decide who becomes president.
 - (B) Polls count only the candidates.
 - (C) Polls ask every Brazilian.
 - (D) Polls usually ask only thousands of people.
6. What does Lula say oil money can help pay for?
 - (A) Cleaner energy
 - (B) His son's campaign
 - (C) Voting fines
 - (D) More opinion polls

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Voters who had not decided: Many voters had not chosen whom to support shortly before election day.
2. Some environmentalists: They have criticised recent actions.
3. Lula: He says oil money can help pay for cleaner energy and that he plans to end fossil-fuel use eventually.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):